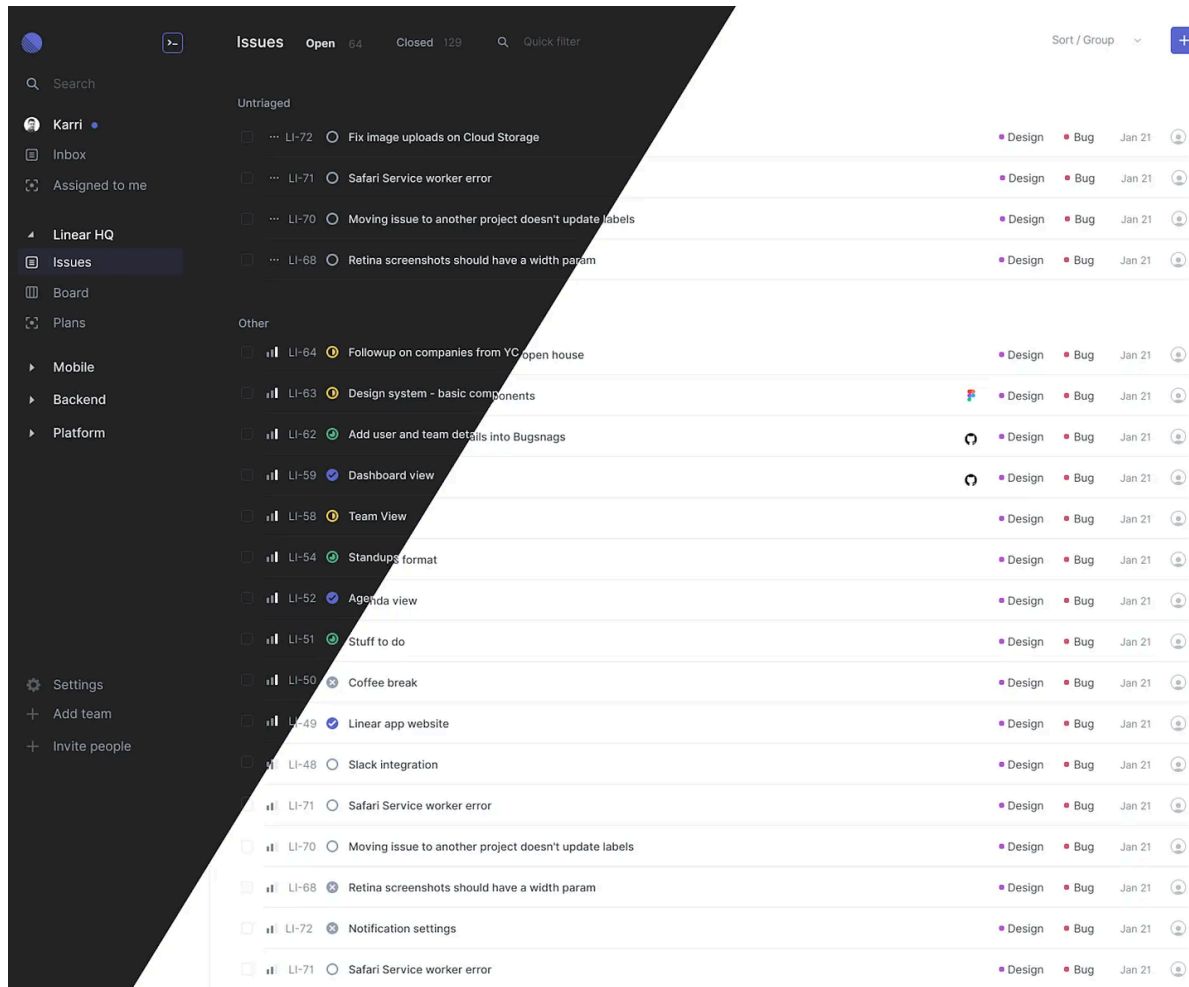




Linear strategy

Background



Linear's app was built as a chrome extension right inside Airbnb in order to simplify the current use of their issue tracking tool: Jira

▼ Why did they decide to build Linear?

- **There was a clear interest of simplifying and beautifying issue tracker - as IC dislike huge and complex project management**
 - The Airbnb team loves it - especially the product team

- **Product companies don't really have any methodology for building products.**
 - Even big tech seriously

▼ How did they do it?

▼ Images



https://x.com/karrisaarine/status/1118968678714707968?ref_src=twsrc%5Etfw%7Ctwcamp%5Etweetembed%7Ctwterm%5E1118968678714707968%7Ctwgr%5E0bf4b6c75348ed88f82cc3c05c2d501ac982a9ed%7Ctwcon%5Es1.&ref_url=https%3A%2F%2Fwww.notion.so%2Fandrei-knm%2FLinear-strategy-194564b7f25f803d898fc9e05e0824cc

- They target their current colleagues & people with same mindset as them like small startup and product team → Especially Developers (as it was validated right inside Airbnb)
- Start small with issue tracking and focus on ICs working at smaller companies, initially. As these companies grow, we'd build up more functionality and support scaleups.
- One of their first core mission was to become top the best tool to ever be used by all startup for issue tracking
- They aim to solve inefficiency of issue tracking and project management as it's complexity of Jira
- In the first two year, their aim was to have **PMF in small segments** focusing the niche of building small product for small team

- As they started getting larger companies, they noticed that *"Yeah, it's not really great for you right now, but let's work on it, making it better,"* and that is Linear's product-market fit strategy for the next few years.

▼ GPT summarize

- **Founders' Network and Reputation:** The founders leveraged their established Silicon Valley backgrounds and large Twitter followings to attract users to the waitlist²⁴.
- **Problem Awareness:** Karri Saarinen noticed negative sentiment towards existing issue tracking software like Jira during his time at Airbnb, which helped him understand the market need for a simpler tool²⁴. He even created a Chrome extension to simplify Jira, which gained popularity within Airbnb's product team².
- **Early Interest:** The founders managed to get 10,000 people on the waitlist in just two months for their closed beta².
- **Strategic Incubation:** Linear spent time incubating the product concept before launching the private beta².
- **MVP Validation:** Linear spent a full year validating their Minimum Viable Product (MVP) in a closed beta, slowly onboarding users from the waitlist².
- **Constant Testing:** Linear emphasized getting the initial concept tested on real users as soon as possible and for as long as possible². They continue to test each new feature in beta before officially launching it².

▼ Linear founder have tremendous pedigree → Fame

▼ History

- **Shared History:** Lallo and Saarinen met around 2008 within the Helsinki startup community¹.
- **Previous Startup Experience:** Saarinen and Lallo co-founded Kippt, a collaborative bookmarking system, and participated in Y Combinator in 2012¹⁴⁵. Kippt was later acquired by Coinbase in 2014¹.

- **Experience in Prominent Tech Companies:** Before founding Linear, all three founders held senior positions at well-known tech companies¹². Saarinen was a Principal Designer at Airbnb, Lallo was a Senior Engineer at Coinbase, and Artman was a Senior Engineer at Uber¹.
- **Strategic Career Moves:** Artman consciously took jobs in Silicon Valley to prepare for his next startup²⁶.
- **Recognitions:** Saarinen received the Ruby Hero award in 2013 and a Material Design Award from Google in 2016 for Airbnb's mobile apps⁴.
- **Inspired by Frustrations:** They all experienced the hassle of switching between various software management tools, which they felt were not as helpful or elegant as they could have been, which led them to create Linear¹.
- Thanks to their large Twitter followings, founders managed to line up 10,000 people for the waitlist for their closed beta.
- And who were those early beta users, you ask? Oh, just a few of the buddies from these little future unicorns like Cohere, Runway, and Ramp.
- Around the same time, Sequoia partner came knocking with a \$4.2M seed round because, *"people she trusts in her Twitter network were hyped about Linear."*

▼ When did linear.app started to get money?

- **Linear started** getting funding in November 2019 with a \$4.2 million seed round led by Sequoia.
 - In December 2020, they raised a \$13 million Series A funding round, also led by Sequoia Capital.
 - A Series B round for \$35 million, led by Accel, followed in September 2023.
- So they must have money backed in order to stay operate
- Linear has been profitable since 2021, a year after launching the product.
 - They have maintained a negative lifetime burn rate, meaning they had more cash in the bank than they had raised from investors.

- Until their Series B funding, Linear had more money in the bank than it had raised from investors.
-

▼ Some problem Linear face

- Linear faced the challenge of adapting its product to suit the needs of larger organizations as it expanded beyond its initial focus on small startups
 - The tool, initially designed for smaller, dynamic teams, might not have been a perfect fit for larger companies with more complex processes
 - Linear acknowledged this and expressed a commitment to improving the product to better serve these larger organizations in the future
-

▼ Linear go to market strategy

- **Organic Growth Focus:** Linear had achieved significant growth with very little investment in marketing, relying heavily on organic, word-of-mouth growth
 - **Brand Building:** Cordova aimed to build a strong brand for the company, expanding Linear's reach to more software and product builders globally². She emphasized the importance of a compelling story to differentiate Linear
 - **Work Trials:** Linear uses work trials to determine whether someone is a builder and has good taste
-

▼ Linear is narrative

Linear is influencing by bringing obvious beautiful design into old complex industry

My thoughts

Linear is a tool for builder (IC in startup mostly engineer), built by builder

Linear principles:

- It should be **as fast as possible** (local data storage, no page reloads, available offline).
- It should be **modern** (keyboard shortcuts, command menu, contextual menus).

- It should be **multiplayer** (real-time sync and teammates presence).

Two problems that linear are solving:

- ICs dislike their current project management solutions
- Product companies don't really have any methodology for building products

Linear mission is to focus mainly on how to accelerate building and manual workflow

- **Bottom up approach** helps them leverage opportunity → The more new startups that form or engineering organizations get set up without the baggage of existing enterprise-wide processes, the more entry points for Linear present themselves.
- Focus was on **small product/ engineering teams**. Building a simple product has positioned Linear as the easiest way to start building software
- → Why? Start up team **usually are Individual Contributor** with no Onboarding experience so building for them **ensure a small segments niche of the market**

Linear key success are focused on branding and narrative

- → Why? This term is abstract so what they are doing is that they **use their voice (post, social media, founder talk,) to explain the workflow methodology of the workflow process** that can be used in Linear and how to map **to each company/ IC workflows**
- → Emphasize the story telling and the value its attracting and it let user do their own

▼ Core

- Please note that this was a key to accelerate momentum built based on early 10000 beta users → Hype the fan base → Making story telling through hint of product → This fit the customer base of developer/ IC
- Linear narrative story:
 - Open with what's good and what's bad
 - Critique the current problem that user are facing
 - Hint a solution from a better product: Linear

- Outlining details with each guideline and CTA for each step
- Emphasis on the Values: Linear abstract the value as not needed PM and hence designer and developer should work together → Focusing on IC, remove blocker
- Show the outcome of the product both from other company achievement through using Linear and the Linear product quality

But the whole core in order to reach IC customer is by fame? How can we get it?

- Engage in more content and personal branding to highlight expertise → Like telling a story of Cigro/ Endash through through blog posts, social media, videos, webinars, and speaking opportunities.... Sneak peak of even a small changes in button of Cigro/ Endash
- Focus on current user base and keep them engaged → This is the product part → Like highlighting their success on our product
- Highlight key point of which if you switch to Endash what will you get and the list of possible questions
- Attract investor through Endash only

Reflecting to Endash

- From my personal perspective, I think the product is still going in the right direction, we need to solve the financial part in order to explode

→ My thought is still, we **translate the custom dashboard process into easy to use for IC, we find our PMF**

- Note from Linear
 - **Narrow down your initial audience and build for them:** Figure out who you're building the product for and make the target audience as small as possible before expanding.
- → Focus solely on IC in creating report and Manager for getting Insight
 - **Build and leverage your waitlist:** The waitlist is the grinding stone with which you can sharpen your idea into something truly valuable that will succeed at market, so use it effectively.

- **Trust your gut and validate demand with your users:** Talk, talk, talk to your users and find out how invested in the product they are (and if they'd be willing to pay)

<https://linear.app/switch#who-else-is-switching>

<https://newsletter.pragmaticengineer.com/p/linear>

<https://linear.app/blog/rethinking-the-startup-mvp-building-a-competitive-product>

<https://research.contrary.com/company/linear>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xxeUVwjUm5M>
